

OTHER COPILOT TOOLS

Beyond Chat: Other Copilot Tools Worth Trying

A tour of Copilot inside Word, PowerPoint, Excel, and Copilot Chat — plus responsible-use notes for student data.

Copilot is more than a chat box

Most instructors only ever meet Copilot as a chat window. It also shows up inside Word, PowerPoint, Excel, and other Microsoft 365 apps most CTE programs already have — each with a different job to do.

DRAFTING & REWRITING HANDOUTS

Copilot in Word

Draft a syllabus, permission slip, or safety agreement, then ask Copilot to rewrite it at a lower reading level or shorten it for a one-page handout. Works well for polishing something you've already roughed out rather than starting from nothing.

VISUAL AIDS & SAFETY POSTERS

Copilot in PowerPoint / Designer

Describe a shop safety poster or a slide deck outline in plain language and Designer will generate visual layout options. Useful for signage, PPE reminders, and station instruction cards that need to look clean, not just read clean.

GRADE TRACKING & SUPPLY ORDERING

Copilot in Excel

Ask Copilot to build a competency-tracking spreadsheet with formulas for pass/fail thresholds, or to draft a supply reorder list from a shop inventory count. Good for the administrative side of running a program, not just the classroom side.

WORKING FROM YOUR ACTUAL MATERIALS

Copilot Chat with your own files

In Copilot Chat (Microsoft 365), you can reference an uploaded document directly — a rubric, a unit plan, an equipment manual — and ask Copilot to work from that specific file instead of guessing at your context. This produces far more usable results than a prompt with no attached material.

DIAGRAMS & VISUAL REFERENCE SHEETS

Image generation

Generate a labeled diagram or visual reference (e.g., parts of a table saw, a wiring schematic style illustration) as a starting point — always verify technical accuracy against a real reference before posting it in a shop.

DIFFERENTIATION ON DEMAND

Reading-level rewriting

Paste any handout or textbook excerpt and ask for a version at a specific grade level. This is one of the highest-value, lowest-effort uses of Copilot for CTE classrooms with mixed reading levels.

Responsible use with student data

- Don't paste identifiable student data (full names + grades + disability status, etc.) into Copilot unless your district has confirmed the specific tool is approved for that use.
- Use placeholders ("Student A," "a student reading below grade level") instead of real names when drafting differentiated materials.
- Check your district or state's current AI use policy before using Copilot output directly in an IEP-related document.
- Treat anything Copilot drafts as a starting point that carries your name once you use it — you're accountable for what goes in front of students, the same as with any other resource.

A five-minute way to try one new thing

Pick one tool from this list you haven't used. Open it, and try exactly one of the example prompts above with a real topic from your program this week. Small, repeated use builds fluency faster than trying to overhaul a whole unit at once.